

Verbena officinalis (Verbenaceae)

Vervain, Ma Bian Cao (Chinese)

Vervain has long been credited with magical properties and was used in ceremonies by the Druids of ancient Britain and Gaul. It is a traditional herbal medicine in both China and Europe. Dioscorides in the 1st century CE called vervain the “sacred herb,” and for many centuries it was taken as a cure-all. It has tonic, restorative properties, and is used to relieve stress and anxiety and to improve digestive function.



Vervain was carried in the Middle Ages to bring good luck.

Habitat & Cultivation

Vervain grows wild throughout much of Europe and North Africa as well as in China and Japan. It is propagated from seed in spring or autumn and thrives in well-drained soil in a sunny position. The aerial parts are harvested in summer when the plant is in flower.

Related Species

Blue vervain (*V. hastata*), which is native to North America, is used medicinally in the same way as vervain.

Key Constituents

- Bitter iridoids (verbena, verbenalin)
- Volatile oil
- Alkaloids
- Triterpenes (beta-sitosterol)
- Flavonoids

Key Actions

- Nervine
- Tonic
- Mild bitter
- Mild antidepressant

Research

■ **Hormonal effects** Early indications from research into vervain are that it has both estrogenic and progestogenic activity. It also stimulates the muscles of the womb, and production of breast milk.

■ **Lack of research** For an herb with such long traditional use, surprisingly little research into vervain has occurred to date. Laboratory studies indicate that vervain has significant anti-inflammatory activity. It may also have antiviral and liver-protective properties. Verbenalin, an active compound within vervain, is strongly bitter; may cause vomiting at high doses, and stimulates contraction of the womb.

Traditional & Current Uses

■ **Digestive tonic** Vervain improves the function of the digestive system and absorption of food.

■ **Nervous system** Vervain is prized as a restorative for the nervous system and is especially helpful for nervous tension. It is thought to have a mild antidepressant action, and is used specifically to treat anxiety and the nervous exhaustion that follows long-term stress.

■ **Convalescence** By aiding digestion and restoring the nervous system, vervain is an ideal tonic for people recovering from chronic illness.

■ **Headaches & migraines** Vervain alleviates headaches, and in Chinese herbal medicine it is used for migraines connected with the menstrual cycle.

■ **Other uses** Among its other medicinal uses, vervain is given



Vervain

A slender perennial growing to 3 ft (1 m), with stiff, thin stems and spikes of small lilac flowers.

Parts Used

Aerial parts have a tonic effect on the nervous system and digestion, and have been used medicinally for thousands of years in Europe and China.

Vervain has slender, almost “wandlike,” flowering stems



Dried aerial parts



Fresh aerial parts

Key Preparations & Their Uses

⚠ **Cautions** Do not exceed the stated dose. Vervain can cause vomiting if taken in excess. Do not take during pregnancy.



Tincture (to make, p. 292) is a relaxing, calming tonic. For stress and anxiety, take ½ tsp diluted in a glass of water 3 times a day.



Infusion (to make, p. 291) helps stimulate digestion and improves effective absorption of food. Drink ¾ cup (150 ml) regularly, particularly after heavy meals.



Powder can be used as a toothpaste. Rub on the teeth regularly to clean and protect them.

Self-help Uses

- Nervous exhaustion, p. 309.
- Premenstrual syndrome, p. 315.

for jaundice, gallstones, asthma, insomnia, premenstrual syndrome, flu, and fevers.